

# ❖ STUDY BEES ❖

## POEM – TWO MOTHERS REMEMBERED

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## About the Poem

"Two Mothers Remembered" is a reflective, autobiographical poem by Joann Snow Duncanson, written in six rhyming quatrains. The speaker describes how her one mother effectively became "two mothers" over the course of her life: the loving, familiar mother of her childhood and adulthood, and a later, greatly changed mother whose mind clouded with age or illness. The poem closes by passing on the lesson of unconditional love to the speaker's own children.

## Paraphrasing

### Stanza 1:

*I had two Mothers – two Mothers I claim,  
Two different people, yet with the same name.  
Two separate women, diverse by design,  
But I loved them both because they were mine.*

### Paraphrasing:

The speaker announces the poem's central idea: she had, in effect, two mothers, both called by the same name, "Mother." Though they were two very different women, she loved them both simply and completely because they belonged to her.

### Stanza 2:

*The first was the Mother who carried me here,  
Gave birth and nurtured and launched my career.  
She was the one whose features I bear,  
Complete with the facial expressions I wear.*

### Paraphrasing:

The speaker describes her first mother – the one who gave birth to her, raised her, and helped set her on her path in life. This is the mother whose physical features and facial expressions the speaker recognises in herself.

### Stanza 3:

*She gave me her love, which follows me yet,  
Along with the examples in life she set.  
As I got older, she somehow younger grew,  
And we'd laugh as just Mothers and daughters do.*

### Paraphrasing:

This first mother gave the speaker a lasting love that stays with her still, along with the example she set through her own life. As the speaker grew older, her mother seemed to grow more youthful and light-hearted in spirit, and the two shared an easy, joyful relationship.

#### Stanza 4:

*But then came the time that her mind clouded so,  
And I sensed that the Mother I knew would soon go.  
So quickly she changed and turned into the other,  
A stranger who dressed in the clothes of my Mother.*

#### Paraphrasing:

Eventually, however, the mother's mind began to grow confused – suggesting the onset of dementia or a similar illness – and the speaker sensed that the mother she had always known was slipping away. Rapidly, her familiar mother seemed to change into someone else: a stranger who merely wore her mother's outward appearance.

#### Stanza 5:

*Oh, she looked the same, at least at arm's length,  
But now she was the child and I was her strength.  
We'd come full circle, we women three,  
My Mother the first, the second and me.*

#### Paraphrasing:

Although this “second mother” still looked the same from a distance, the relationship had reversed: she had become like a child, and the speaker was now the one offering strength and support. The speaker reflects that the family had “come full circle,” recognising three distinct figures in this journey – her original mother, this changed version of her, and herself.

#### Stanza 6:

*And if my own children should come to a day,  
When a new Mother comes and the old goes away,  
I'd ask of them nothing that I didn't do.  
Love both of your Mothers as both have loved you.*

#### Paraphrasing:

In closing, the speaker turns to address her own children directly, telling them that if she herself should one day change in the same way, she would ask nothing of them except what she herself had done: to love both versions of their mother, just as both versions had loved them.

## Rhyming Scheme

The poem is written in six quatrains, each following a regular AABB rhyming-couplet scheme (for example, *claim / name* and *design / mine* in the first stanza). This steady, gentle rhyme pattern runs consistently through every stanza, giving the poem the flowing, song-like quality of a spoken reflection or a piece meant to be read aloud, fitting for its personal, reminiscent tone.

## Theme

“Two Mothers Remembered” explores the emotional experience of watching a parent change profoundly through age or illness, and the way caregiving roles between parent and child can reverse over time. At its heart, the poem is about unconditional love: the speaker’s message is that a parent should be loved fully in every version they become, and that this same lesson of steady, unconditional love should be carried forward and taught to the next generation.

## Figures of Speech

- **Extended Metaphor**

The mother’s decline into confusion is described throughout as her turning into “the other” or a “second Mother” – an extended metaphor for the personality changes often caused by illnesses such as dementia.

- **Symbolism**

The phrase “her mind clouded so” symbolises the confusion and memory loss associated with dementia or old age.

- **Repetition**

Phrases like “two Mothers” and “Mother the first, the second and me” are repeated to reinforce the poem’s central idea of duality.

- **Paradox**

The description of the mother growing “younger” in spirit as the speaker herself grows older is a gentle paradox, later echoed and reversed when the mother becomes genuinely childlike due to illness.

- **Imagery**

Physical imagery such as “the features I bear” and “the clothes of my Mother” makes the emotional transformation feel concrete and visible.

- **Motif of Role Reversal**

The recurring idea that “she was the child and I was her strength” is the poem’s central motif, capturing how caregiving roles can reverse between parent and child.

- **Direct Address**

The final stanza turns to address “my own children” directly, extending the poem’s reflection forward to a future generation.

## Questions & Answers

### Q1. What does the speaker mean by saying she had “two Mothers”?

She means that, over the course of her life, her one mother effectively became two very different people: her original, familiar mother, and a later, changed version caused by illness or age.

### Q2. What did the speaker inherit from her first mother?

She inherited her mother’s physical features and facial expressions, as well as her mother’s love and the example she set through her own life.

### Q3. What change does the speaker notice in her mother in the fourth stanza?

Her mother’s mind “clouded,” and she quickly seemed to turn into an unfamiliar stranger, even though she still looked physically the same.

**Q4. What role reversal takes place between the mother and daughter?**

The daughter, once cared for by her mother, now becomes the one giving strength and support, while her mother becomes like a child.

**Q5. What does the phrase “we'd come full circle” mean in this poem?**

It means the cycle of caregiving has reversed and returned to its starting point: just as the mother once cared for her child, the grown child now cares for her mother.

**Q6. What request does the speaker make of her own children at the end of the poem?**

She asks that, if she herself should ever change in the same way, her children love both versions of her, just as she loved both versions of her own mother.

**Q7. What is the central theme of the poem?**

The poem explores unconditional love through a parent's decline, showing how caregiving roles between parent and child can reverse, while teaching that love should remain constant through such change.